Frenchtown Sun

A Frenchtown-Focused Civic Newsletter

*Photographer: Paul Serra*

## Improvements to S. Washington Street scheduled to commence

The South Washington Street improvement project is set to begin the first week of April.

The project includes the installation of some concrete curbs, construction of ADA curb ramps, some drainage improvements, HMA milling, full-depth pavement repairs, full-width pavement resurfacing, traffic striping, signage and site restoration along Hawk Street (from Trenton Avenue to Front Street), Front Street (from Hawk Street to terminus), South Washington Street (from Trenton Avenue to River Road) and River Road (from South Washington Street to terminus at borough wastewater treatment plant).

There may be intermittent road closures during the project, but the Frenchtown Police Department will work to ensure minimal disruption.

## Operation Blue Angel will help residents during medical emergencies

The Frenchtown Police Department, in partnership with the Age-Friendly Frenchtown Initiative, now offers Operation Blue Angel, a voluntary program designed to assist Frenchtown Borough residents who are at risk of a medical or life-threatening emergency and may be home alone, unable to get to the front door to open it for help.

The program allows first responders to enter a resident's home without unnecessary delays or potential damage to windows or doors when someone is unable to answer the door.

Participants in Operation Blue Angel are provided with a free, secured lock box that is affixed near the front entrance of their home. A house key is securely stored inside the lock box, and a confidential access code is placed on file with the Police Department.

In the event of an emergency, a police officer will access the code and use the key to accompany medical personnel into the home.

To be eligible for Operation Blue Angel, Frenchtown residents must be at least 55 years old or have a medical condition that could lead to incapacitation; live alone or are alone for extended periods regularly. They may complete the required application and liability waiver forms and designate an emergency contact person. Visit www.frenchtownpolice.com for the application and waiver or contact the Police Department at 908-996-4820.

## Who we are

*The Frenchtown Sun* is published monthly by the Borough of Frenchtown to provide its residents with local news and community updates.

The content of *The Sun* is guided by the editorial team of Ted Brandston, Randi Eckel, Rick Epstein, John Gattuso, Jeanne Herb, Amelia Rodriguez and Maria Whelan. John Dougherty serves as the Borough Council liaison.

You are reading the first edition of *The Frenchtown Sun* published in April 2026, featuring news from civic and community-based organizations across the borough.

*The Sun* is delivered monthly free of charge to all Frenchtown Borough residents. An online edition is available at www.frenchtownsun.net.

Borough residents can request home delivery or contact the editorial team at newsletter@frenchtownboro.com or mail *The Frenchtown Sun*, 29 Second Street, Frenchtown, N.J. 08825.

## Letter from the editor

I moved to Frenchtown in the early months of the Covid-19 pandemic. What I thought would be the beginnings of a charming life in a colorful small town was instead full of distance and isolation. Despite this bleak beginning, Frenchtown has demonstrated again and again over the last six years that we are a community of generous support, value and friendship.

Whether it's chatting with neighbors on my front porch, waving to visitors on the path during a midday run or bumping into friends old and new during Riverfest, our little hamlet on the river has become my most treasured place: my home.

During an Age-Friendly Initiative survey conducted last year, we learned that residents want to feel more connected to their community and weren't always clear where to get important information about what was happening in the borough. I hope that this monthly newsletter helps residents feel a sense of belonging with this special town.

Everyone must start somewhere, and I dream that *The Frenchtown Sun* will grow over time to be a meaningful contribution to our community. I hope you will join me on this journey to share all that this magnificent borough has to offer.
—*Maria Whelan*

## Meet your mayor

**BRAD MYHRE** was born and raised in Frenchtown Borough and has served as mayor since 2015.

During his tenure, Myhre has helped lead several important infrastructure improvements and redevelopment initiatives that have strengthened the community and supported the borough's continued growth. In addition to his work in local government, Myhre is a dedicated fan of the New York Giants and Penn State Nittany Lions football, and enjoys spending time with friends, testing his knowledge during trivia nights at Wild Fern Brewery.

## Meet your Borough Council

**MICHELE LIEBTAG** is President of the Frenchtown Borough Council and Commissioner, overseeing the police and fire departments. She has been a borough resident since 2003. Michele is also the vice chair of the Hunterdon County Democratic Committee and the political and education director for CWA Local 1036.

## Meet your Borough Council continued

**KATHLEEN BERNHARDT** was elected to the council in 2023. She is the council liaison to the Frenchtown Library and the Department of Public Works. Bernhardt has been a resident of Hunterdon County for more than 30 years, living in Frenchtown since 2018. A former Frenchtown business owner (The Junto Emporium), Bernhardt can now be found most evenings working as hostess at FiNNBAR.

**JOHN DOUGHERTY** was elected to the council in 2023. He has been living in Frenchtown since 1993. He has served on the borough's Planning Board for more than a decade. He is a hydrogeologist with extensive professional experience assessing groundwater contamination at Superfund sites across the United States.

**BILL O'BRIEN** was elected to the council in 2020. O'Brien has been a Frenchtown resident since 1997. He was a member of the Frenchtown Environmental Commission from 2014 to 2020. He enjoys wandering and exploring the beautiful Delaware Valley with his camera.

**HANNAH OPDYKE** was elected to the council in 2022. She serves as the Economic Development Committee chairperson and a member of the Public Safety/OEM Committee. Born and raised in Frenchtown, Opdyke is co-owner of the Sunbeam General Store. She actively donates her time and resources to local causes.

**ELAINE WARNER** serves on the Sanitation & Public Health, Public Safety/OEM, and Budget/Finance/Personnel Committees, in addition to her work on the council. Warner grew up in Frenchtown before moving to Lambertville where she raised her family. Warner is a small-business owner in Hunterdon County.

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## Police focusing on distracted driving

The Police Department received various grants throughout the year for traffic enforcement. April is Distracted Driving Awareness Month. Officers will be conducting distracted driving enforcement details throughout the borough.

The U.S. Drug Enforcement Agency (DEA) National Prescription Drug Takeback Day is Saturday, April 25, from 10 a.m. to 2 p.m. This program offers safe, free and anonymous disposal of unused or expired medications. The Frenchtown Police Department is a collection site year-round.

## Frenchtown Public Library

The Frenchtown Public Library is open for business after recent improvements, including air quality remediation and a new wood floor.

The library hours are Mondays and Tuesdays, 3:30-7 p.m. and Thursdays and Fridays, 9:30 a.m.-1 p.m.

Computers, printers and copiers are available for use. The Frenchtown library is part of the Hunterdon County Library system and its Main Library Alliance. We have full access to the system catalog and librarian Kelly Pickering can assist with obtaining a library card, ordering materials, and helping to access digital resources available to all library patrons.

On the second and fourth Tuesday of each month, canine friends visit the library from 6 to 6:45 p.m. Young friends are invited to try their read-aloud skills on golden retrievers Marley and Jake.

## Planning Board

The Frenchtown Planning Board and Board of Adjustment meets at 7 p.m. on the fourth Wednesday of every month at Borough Hall. All meetings are also streamed live, via Zoom, and past meetings can be viewed on the borough's YouTube channel.

# Community Calendar

**WEDNESDAY, APRIL 1, 6 p.m.**
**Movie Night, (Zootopia 2) Police Department & Frenchtown School**
Frenchtown School, 902 Harrison St.

**FRIDAY, APRIL 3, 5-7 p.m.**
**Fish Fry Fridays at the American Legion**
510 Harrison St.
$15, includes two pieces of fried flounder, French fries and coleslaw. Eat-in or take-out. Open to the public.

**SATURDAY, APRIL 4, 10 a.m.-noon.**
**Annual Easter Egg Hunt by Lions Club**
Old Frenchtown Field

**SATURDAY, APRIL 4, 2 p.m.**
**Bad Luck & Poor Choices Tour (downtown Frenchtown) with Rick Epstein**
$20, but free for teens. Half the proceeds go to the Frenchtown United Methodist Church Open Door Food Pantry.
To register and learn the starting point, email RickEpstein@yahoo.com

**TUESDAY, APRIL 7, 11 a.m.–1:30 p.m.**
**Frenchtown Community Service & Outreach Group's Super Senior Group**
Frenchtown Presbyterian Church, 20 Fourth St.
Free for adults over 55. Yoga with Priscilla, lunch, and guest speaker Jean Miller on native bees.

**WEDNESDAY, APRIL 8, 7 p.m.**
**Borough Council Meeting**
Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

**WEDNESDAY, APRIL 8, 7 p.m.**
**Trivia Night**
Frenchtown American Legion, 510 Harrison St.
Open to the public.

**SATURDAY, APRIL 11, 1-4 p.m.**
**Hunterdon County 2026 Disabilities Service Expo.**
Route 12 County Complex, Raritan Township
This event is designed to allow people to learn about agencies and programs that offer a variety of services for people with disabilities. Free and open to the public.

**SATURDAY, APRIL 11, 2 p.m.**
**Downtown Tour with Rick Epstein**
$20, but free for teens. Half the proceeds go to the Milford-Holland Rescue Squad. This tour can be navigated in a wheelchair.
To register and learn the starting point, email RickEpstein@yahoo.com

**MONDAY, APRIL 13, 6 p.m.**
**Social Justice Book Club**
Frenchtown Presbyterian Church, 20 Fourth St.
Open to everyone concerned with the needs of others, regardless of faith or political leanings.
Questions can be directed to
rev.emily.mcc@gmail.com

**THURSDAY, APRIL 16, 7 p.m.**
**Delaware Valley Historical Society**
Del Val High School, 19 Senator Stout Rd.
Talk by Jim Davidson, author of *Gruesome and Grisly Murders in Hunterdon.* Free admission.

**SATURDAY, APRIL 18, 8–11:30 a.m. (or until trucks are full)**
**Hunterdon Country Shredding Event**
Route 12 County Complex, Raritan Township

**SATURDAY, APRIL 18, 9 a.m. – 12 p.m.**
**Raritan Headwaters Association 36th Annual Stream Cleanup**
Nishisakawick Creek at Frenchtown Borough Park
Participants must register at
www.raritanheadwaters.org/streamcleanup

**SUNDAY, APRIL 19, 8-11 a.m.**
**Breakfast at Darcy Lodge**
39 Everittstown Rd.
$12 per person aged 13+, $7 per person aged 6-12, children under 5 eat free; all-you-can-eat buffet breakfast

**TUESDAY, APRIL 21, 11 a.m.–1:30 p.m.**
**Frenchtown Community Service & Outreach Group's Super Senior Group**
Frenchtown Presbyterian Church, 20 Fourth St.
Free for adults over 55. Yoga with Priscilla, lunch, and guest speaker Valentina Valencia, Crossroad for Hope.

## Community Calendar continued

**WEDNESDAY, APRIL 22, 7 p.m.**
**Trivia Night**
Frenchtown American Legion, 510 Harrison St.
Open to the public.

**FRIDAY, APRIL 24, 6:45 p.m.**
**Frenchtown School Board Meeting**
Frenchtown School, 902 Harrison St.

**SATURDAY, APRIL 25, 10 a.m.–5 p.m.**
**Friends of the Hunterdon County Library Book Sale**
South County Park Fairgrounds, 1207 Route 179
The sale will continue on Sunday, April 26 10 a.m.-3 p.m. (Half-Price Day) and Monday, April 27 9 a.m. – 2 p.m. (Bag Sale)

**SATURDAY, APRIL 25, 10 a.m.**
**Frenchtown Police Department & Frenchtown School Autism Walk**
at the school

**SUNDAY, APRIL 26, 11 a.m.-6 p.m.**
**Third Annual Green Fair**
Sunbeam Park
Join the Frenchtown Business & Professional Association for the third annual Green Fair. There will be local vendors, eco-artisans, healthy bites, environmental organizations, eco-crafts for all ages and a "Buy Nothing" tent where everything is free to a good home. *Rain date: Monday, April 27, 11 a.m.–6 p.m.*

**SUNDAY, APRIL 26, 2 p.m.**
**Lower Cemetery Tour with Rick Epstein**
$20, but free for teens. All proceeds go to help buy a tombstone for 1996 homicide victim Wendy Louise Baker, who was buried under a Jane Doe marker. To register, email RickEpstein@yahoo.com

**MONDAY, APRIL 27, 6 p.m.**
**Social Justice Book Club**
Frenchtown Presbyterian Church, 20 Fourth St.
Open to everyone concerned with the needs of others, regardless of faith or political leanings. Questions can be directed to rev.emily.mcc@gmail.com

**WEDNESDAY, APRIL 29, 7 p.m.**
**Borough Council Meeting**
Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

**TUESDAY, MAY 5, 11 a.m. – 1:30 p.m.**
**Frenchtown Community Service & Outreach Group's Super Senior Group**
Frenchtown Presbyterian Church, 20 Fourth St.
Free for adults over 55. Yoga with Priscilla, lunch, and guest speaker Virigina Woo, The Butterfly Miracle.

**WEDNESDAY, MAY 6, 7 p.m.**
**Borough Council Meeting**
Borough Hall, 29 Second St.

**THURSDAY, MAY 7, 5 p.m.**
**Clam Night at the American Legion**
510 Harrison St.

**THURSDAY, MAY 7, 6:30 p.m.**
**Frenchtown School Spring Concert**
Frenchtown School, 902 Harrison St.

## Frenchtown churches

### FRENCHTOWN PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH

A social justice book club, hosted by Frenchtown Presbyterian Church Pastor Emily McCachren and Frenchtown United Methodist Church Pastor Peter Mantell, kicked off in March. The group read selections from *Just Mercy: A Story of Justice and Redemption* by Bryan Stevenson. They meet on the second and fourth Monday of each month at 6 p.m. If you have questions, contact Rev. McCachren at rev.emily.mcc@gmail.com.

### FRENCHTOWN UNITED METHODIST CHURCH

Every Tuesday and Friday morning, the Frenchtown United Methodist Church cooking club cooks from 9:30 a.m. until noon. The club prepares about 200 meals for the Open Door Community Pantry.

If you would like to the donate to the pantry, commonly needed items include: shelf-stable milk, tomato products, peanut butter, jelly, cereals, no sugar-added juices, soups, mac and cheese, canned tuna, canned chicken, canned vegetables and canned fruits.

## Frenchtown School

In March, therapy dogs visited Frenchtown School students for Read Across America week. Ms. Pickering from the Frenchtown Library came to read to the elementary students. For her visit, students made puppets of their favorite characters from their favorite books and dressed as those characters for the puppet parade.

After spring break, students will take field trips to the Liberty Science Center, the N.J. State Museum, and the eighth-graders will visit Philadelphia for their culminating class trip before graduating. The PTO will sponsor a planetarium assembly program, and one about eel conservation by the Raritan Headwaters Association.

Preschool through fourth-grade students will perform their spring concert on May 7 at 6:30 p.m., and the Spectrum Showcase—the end-of-year chorus and band concert and art show—will be May 28 at 6 p.m. All are welcome!

**FRENCHTOWN SCHOOL CENTENNIAL CELEBRATION**

On the afternoon of Sept. 26, the Frenchtown School will celebrate its 100th anniversary. The school staff is hard at work planning the celebration. It will be a community birthday party with live music, carnival games, face-painting, food trucks, and possibly a small antique car show.

The highlight will be the opening ceremony, where attendees will learn about the Doughboy statue that adorns the front lawn, as well as the opening of the cornerstone that was placed when the building was built. There will be tours through the building to showcase a wonderful collection of memorabilia and the building itself.

If you, or someone you know, would like to assist with the planning, help build some carnival games, and/or volunteer to help with various tasks on the day of the event, please call Sandy Miller at 908-996-2751 or email smiller@frenchtownschool.org.

Mark your calendars and spread the word! It will be a Frenchtown celebration for all!

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## Age-Friendly Frenchtown

In March 2025, Frenchtown Borough was one of 17 local governments in New Jersey that received a grant from the N.J. Department of Human Services to identify challenges facing older residents throughout the borough.

Over the past eight months, the borough has undertaken an "Age-Friendly" planning process, which will culminate with Borough Council adopting an Age-Friendly Action Plan this June. The Action Plan will summarize challenges and opportunities to promoting Age-Friendliness in the borough and outline priority actions moving forward as part of its Age-Friendly initiative.

A committee of Frenchtown residents has guided the Age-Friendly planning process, this included: inventorying existing services for older residents, conducting a community-wide survey, engaging local leaders, hosting two Mayor's Age-Friendly Town Halls, researching innovative efforts in other communities, and studying data about the borough's population.

Additionally, the Frenchtown Borough Council endorsed the borough's application to join the AARP Network of Age-Friendly States and Communities, and, in August 2025, the borough became the 1,006th community across the country enrolled in the AARP initiative.

Updates to the borough's Age-Friendly initiative will continue to be included in *The Sun.*

## Native wildflower blooms

In the next few weeks, Frenchtown will sprout with patches of a spring wildflower, the Virginia Spring Beauty (*Claytonia virginiana*). Virigina Spring Beauty grows to be about 6 to 10 inches tall and is one of our earliest spring wildflowers. Their fragrant flowers are found in woodlands, lawns, and gardens. By early May, they will quickly decline and go dormant until next spring, leaving behind nothing but their little underground corms (referred to as "fairy potatoes"). —*Randi Eckel*

## Obituaries

**KYLE J. ALLEGER 26**, died on March 10 in Ewing Township as the result of an automobile accident.

He was the son of Joel R. and Sue Ann D. (Sliker) Alleger of Frenchtown.

Kyle was born June 4, 1999, in Princeton and grew up in Frenchtown.

He graduated from Delaware Valley High School in 2017. Kyle worked in the Logistics/Parts Department of Penske Truck Leasing in Burlington.

His dedication to his work was admired by his peers, and he took pride in being part of a team that emphasized efficiency and support.

Besides his loving parents and brother Colin, Kyle is survived by his maternal grandmother, Diane Campbell of Milford; his paternal grandmother, Agnes Alleger of Flemington; and several aunts and uncles, as well as many cousins who will cherish his memory.

His funeral was held on March 17 at Holcombe-Fisher Funeral Home in Flemington and interment was in St. Magdalen Cemetery, Flemington.

Contributions in Kyle's memory may be made to St. Jude Children's Research Hospital.

**DENNIS B. CARR**, 79, of Holland Township passed away on Feb. 17 at St. Luke's Warren Hospital in Phillipsburg. He was president of the Frenchtown Cemetery Association for more than 20 years.

Born on Jan. 3, 1947, in Frenchtown, Dennis lived in Mount Pleasant before to Holland Township 50 years ago. He was a 1965 graduate of Delaware Valley High School.

Dennis was drafted into the Army in 1966, and was stationed in Germany. Afterward, he worked for the U.S. Postal Service for more than 30 years in Morristown, Flemington, Hillsborough, and South River, before retiring in 2001.

Dennis was a member of the Frenchtown American Legion and the Everittstown United Methodist Church, where he taught Sunday school, and served as a trustee. Dennis served his country, his community, and his church faithfully and with quiet dedication. Most of all, he was a dedicated and loving husband, father, and "Pop" or "Poppy" to granddaughter Kylee.

Son of the late William Carr Sr. and Cora (Pursell) Carr, Dennis is survived by his beloved wife of 54 years, Patricia A. (Rounsaville) Carr, his son Eric M. and his wife Nicole, his three brothers Harry, William Jr. and Theodore, his sister Sandra Lutz and her husband William, his granddaughter Kylee, his granddog Baylee, and many nieces, nephews, and friends.

A celebration of Dennis' life will be announced at a later date. Interment will take place at the Frenchtown Cemetery. Arrangements are under the care of the Johnson-Walton Funeral Home, 24 Church Road, Holland Township. Memorial contributions can be made to Frenchtown Cemetery, PO Box 8, Frenchtown 08825.

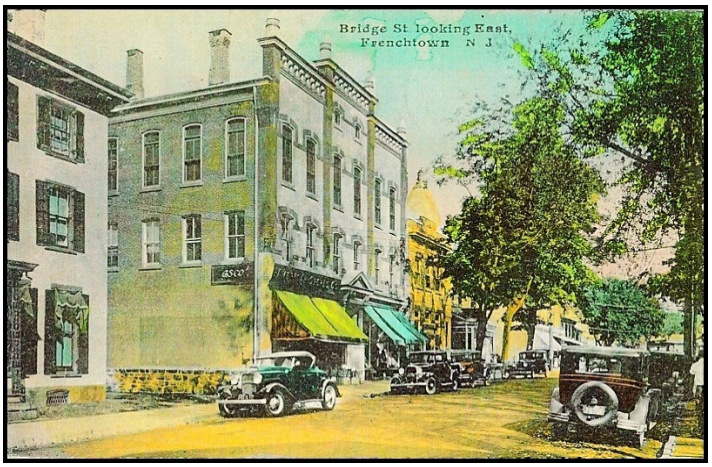
## County Senior Center offerings

The Hunterdon County Senior Center, located at 4 Gauntt Place in Flemington, offers a variety of programs, activities and opportunities. Membership to the Senior Center is free for all county residents 60+ years of age.

Offerings at the Senior Center include:

- Exercise classes, health, and wellness activities, including dance classes, Tai Chi, Qi Gong, meditation and yoga
- Foreign language and art classes
- A technology help and Tech Roundtable talks on technology
- Support groups, including for people with limited vision and those experiencing grief
- Health education classes, in-person and hybrid, designed to prevent falls, address osteoporosis, and improve balance
- Use of bocce and cornhole courts
- Lectures on history, arts, travel, gardening
- Recreation and social programs, including board and card games, movies, book clubs, arts and crafts and a choral group

For more information about the Senior Center, call 908-788-1359 or check the center's website: https://www.co.hunterdon.nj.us/495/Senior-Center

# Frenchtown then & now

**THE ODD FELLOWS BUILDING** at 17-19 Bridge Street is 47 feet tall, making it Frenchtown's tallest. Completed in 1897, it was built for the Independent Order of Odd Fellows, Frenchtown's most prestigious and affluent lodge. The lodge brothers, who were dedicated to doing good deeds, met on the third story. When the picture (*below, left*) was taken circa 1930, the lodge was still going strong. In the 2026 photo (*below, right*), the building is missing its next-door neighbor. Over the years, that brick residence was the home of Bridge Street merchants Hugh Warford (b. 1826-d.1887), Charles N. Reading (1854-1919), and Samuel O. Eddy (1864-1934). It was saved from the Great Frenchtown Fire of 1878 by men with ladders, buckets, and strips of wet carpet. But in 1962 Wilbur Stout of Pennington bought it and let it decay, finally demolishing it in 1972. —*Rick Epstein*